

EMERGING SCHOLARS COUNCIL

AMBITION TO ADMISSION

FREE HANDBOOK

PhD Admission Abroad 101

A practical handbook for funded PhD positions in Europe, the UK, the USA and beyond

Dr. Deepak Kumar Malik · Founder, Emerging Scholars Council

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Dr. Deepak Kumar Malik

Founder, Emerging Scholars Council · President, DAAD IndiAlumni

linkedin.com/in/deepmalik8281

I grew up in a village in Haryana, studied life sciences at Delhi University, and did my MSc at IIT Bombay in the Department of Biosciences and Bioengineering. I found my PhD at LMU Munich through a fully funded job advert, and finished it as a DAAD scholar. Today I work as a research scientist in Munich and serve as President of DAAD IndiAlumni, a registered non-profit association of Indian and German DAAD alumni. I started Emerging Scholars Council because I kept answering the same questions from students who were just as capable as anyone abroad, but had nobody to show them how the system works. This handbook is the honest version of those answers.

Want someone in your corner?

At Emerging Scholars Council, our mentors have been through these applications themselves. We work with you one-to-one: where to apply, how to present your research, your CV and letters, and your interviews. If you'd like to talk it through, book a free 15-minute call. Tell us where you are, and we'll tell you honestly what we'd do next.

Book a free call
cal.com/escmentorship/discoverycall

Free guides, webinars and live PhD board
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01

LMU Munich, Germany

CHAPTER 01 — WELCOME

Before you send another email

I went from a village school in Haryana to Delhi University, IIT Bombay and then a PhD at LMU Munich. Nobody explained the system to me; I learned it one mistake at a time. This handbook is the short, honest version I wish I'd had.

It's for you if you're an Indian student in science or engineering and you want a **funded** PhD abroad. You might have a BS-MS, BSc, MSc, MTech, BTech, BPharm or MPharm. You might have done iGEM, a summer internship or a thesis, or you might be starting with very little research experience. It's free, and you don't need to sign up for anything.

Read it once from start to finish. Then come back to the chapter you need, when you need it.

> **KEY TAKEAWAY**
>
> In Europe, a PhD is almost always a paid job. Never accept an unfunded PhD. If nobody is paying you, keep looking.

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How to keep this handbook current

Rules change every year. Scholarship amounts go up, visa rules get rewritten, portals move. So I don't freeze numbers here. Wherever a number matters, I tell you where to check it. Bookmark these official sites:

WHAT YOU NEED	OFFICIAL SITE
German scholarships	DAAD scholarship database (daad.de/en/study-and-research-in-germany/scholarships)
DAAD for Indian applicants	DAAD India (daad.in/en)
PhD jobs across Europe	EURAXESS job search (euraxess.ec.europa.eu/jobs/search)
EU doctoral networks	MSCA Doctoral Networks (marie-sklodowska-curie-actions.ec.europa.eu/actions/doctoral-networks)
German salary tables	TdL (TV-L pay tables) (tdl-online.de)
Living and working in Germany	Make it in Germany (make-it-in-germany.com/en)
UK doctoral funding	UKRI studentships (ukri.org/what-we-do/developing-people-and-skills/find-studentships-and-doctoral-training/get-a-studentship-to-fund-your-doctorate)
USA, from India	USIEF (usief.org.in) and EducationUSA (educationusa.state.gov)

CHECK THE CURRENT RULE

If this handbook and an official page disagree, the official page wins. Look for the date on any page you read. If a call links a document (often a PDF), that document has the binding rules.

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University of Edinburgh, UK

CHAPTER 02 — FUNDING

How PhDs abroad are paid for

Most students skip this chapter. Don't. Each region pays for PhDs differently, and the money decides where and how you apply.

The three ways a PhD gets funded

1. **Employment contract.** The university or institute hires you as a junior researcher and pays you a salary. Tax and social security come off it, and you get health insurance, pension contributions and an employee's rights. This is normal in Germany, the Netherlands, Scandinavia, Switzerland, France and EU doctoral networks.
2. **Scholarship or stipend.** A **stipend** is a fixed monthly payment for living costs, paid to you directly. You are not an employee. It is often tax-free, but you usually don't build up a pension. DAAD scholarships and UK studentships work like this.
3. **Assistantship.** The university pays you to teach (a **teaching assistantship**, TA) or to do research on a professor's grant (a **research assistantship**, RA). It usually comes with a **tuition waiver**, so you pay no fees. This is the US model.

A **PI** (principal investigator) is the professor who leads a research group. Often the PI pays you from a research grant. That's why the relationship with your PI matters so much.

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Contract or scholarship?

	EMPLOYMENT CONTRACT	SCHOLARSHIP OR STIPEND
Tax	Deducted	Often tax-free
Social security	Deducted	Usually none
Health insurance	Through your job	Often your own
Pension record	Yes	Usually not

Neither is better in every way. Compare the **net** amount (what reaches your bank account) plus what's covered.

The whole picture

REGION	USUAL FUNDING	USUAL LENGTH	HOW YOU GET IN
Germany	Contract or DAAD	3–4 years	Adverts, emails, graduate schools
Rest of Western Europe	Contract	3–4 years	Adverts
UK	Studentship	3–4 years	Adverts, doctoral programmes
USA	Assistantship + waiver	5–6 years	Programme application, once a year

The lengths are approximate (2026). Each position states its own.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> A "PhD offer" that asks you to pay tuition, a "bench fee" or a "research fee" is not a funded PhD. In Europe, walk away. Get the funding in writing before you say yes.

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03

TU Munich, Germany

CHAPTER 03 — EUROPE

Germany and the rest of Europe

Germany is the country I know best, and it's a strong option for Indian science students. In international research teams, English is usually the working language. You don't need German for the PhD, though some German makes daily life easier.

Two shapes of German PhD

- **Individual doctorate.** You join one professor's group, through a job advert or by writing to the professor directly.
- **Structured programme.** A graduate school takes a group of students through one call. You get a thesis committee, courses and a cohort.

Structured programmes include the **International Max Planck Research Schools (IMPRS)**, **DFG Research Training Groups** (university programmes funded by the German Research Foundation), and graduate schools at universities and at **Helmholtz**, **Leibniz** and **Fraunhofer** institutes. Many institutes also hire PhD students outside these schools, through their own job pages.

How a German PhD is paid

Most funded German PhDs are employment contracts. Public universities pay according to **TV-L**, the salary agreement for public-sector staff in most German states. PhD posts usually sit in pay group **E13**. **German PhD contracts are usually 50–100% of the TV-L E13 salary**, depending on the field and the institute. The advert states the share.

To see what that means in euros, open the current E13 table on the TdL website (tdl-online.de) and multiply by the percentage in your advert. As a rough guide (approx., 2026), full-time E13 at the first step was a little under €4,800 a month **gross** (before tax and social security). Take-home pay is lower.

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Research institutes such as Max Planck sometimes use their own contract types, so ask the group for the actual monthly amount. The other route is a **DAAD scholarship**, covered in the scholarships chapter.

> **TIP**
>
> Doctoral candidates at German public universities usually pay no tuition. You normally pay only a small **semester contribution** (a fee for student services, often with a local transport ticket).

The Netherlands, the Nordics, Switzerland and France

- **Netherlands.** PhD candidates are usually university employees on a national PhD salary scale. Some universities also have non-employee tracks, so check the contract type.
- **Sweden, Denmark, Norway, Finland.** PhD students are usually salaried employees. In Sweden, doctoral studies normally take four years.
- **Switzerland.** Usually salaried. Pay is high by European standards, and so is the cost of living.
- **France.** The usual route is a **doctoral contract**, a work contract normally for three years.

EU doctoral networks (MSCA)

The **Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions (MSCA) Doctoral Networks** are EU-funded PhD programmes. Universities, institutes and companies in different countries train a group of PhD students together. You get one project, one main host, and planned stays at partners.

- You can be **any nationality**, but you must **not** already hold a doctorate.
- A **mobility rule** says you must not have lived or worked mainly in the host country for more than 12 months in the 36 months before recruitment. This favours students from abroad, like you.
- The EU figures are gross and include the employer's costs. Ask for the expected **net** monthly salary before you compare offers.

You don't apply to "MSCA" itself. Each network advertises its own positions, usually on EURAXESS.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> Read the current mobility rule and allowances on the MSCA Doctoral Networks page (marie-sklodowska-curie-actions.ec.europa.eu/actions/doctoral-networks) and in each advert.

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04

Cornell University, USA

CHAPTER 04 — UK AND USA

The UK and the USA

The UK

A UK PhD usually takes three to four years. Funded positions are called **studentships**: a tax-free stipend plus tuition fees. The biggest public funder, **UKRI** (UK Research and Innovation), sets a minimum stipend each year. As a rough guide (approx., 2026), it was a little under £22,000 a year outside London, more in London. Check the current figure on the UKRI studentship page (ukri.org/what-we-do/developing-people-and-skills/find-studentships-and-doctoral-training/get-a-studentship-to-fund-your-doctorate).

Here's the part most guides skip:

- UKRI pays fees only **up to the home (UK) rate**. International fees are much higher. Unless the university waives the difference, you pay it. Read the advert and ask.
- UKRI funding does **not** pay for your visa or the Immigration Health Surcharge (a fee for using the UK's health service).
- Skip adverts that say "UK/home students only". Look for "open to international students".

The USA

The US system is different in almost every way.

- **You apply to a programme, not a professor.** Each department has its own online application. Most US programmes close between early December and mid-January for a start the following autumn. Check each programme.
- **Funding comes with admission.** Good science and engineering programmes usually fund admitted PhD students through TA or RA posts, fellowships and a tuition waiver. Check that the offer letter says so, and for how many years.
- **It's longer.** Usually five to six years or more. The first years include coursework and a **qualifying exam** you must pass to continue.

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- **Rotations.** Many biology programmes admit you to a department, not a lab. In year one you work in two or three labs, then choose.
- **Tests.** Many programmes have made the GRE optional or dropped it. This varies by department.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> US rules on student visas and work after graduation have been changing. Read the official US government pages and ask your target university's international office before you commit.



05

University of Vienna, Austria

CHAPTER 05 — ROUTES

Which route fits your degree

Your degree decides which doors are open right now. Many students lose a year applying to places that can't admit them.

YOUR DEGREE	EUROPE (INCL. GERMANY)	UK	USA
5-year BS-MS (e.g. IISER)	Direct PhD	Direct PhD	Direct PhD
MSc, MTech, MPharm	Direct PhD	Direct PhD	Direct PhD
4-year BTech, BS, BPharm	Usually Master's first	Sometimes direct	Direct PhD
3-year BSc	Master's first	Often Master's first	Often not direct

Read the table as a starting point, not a rule. Every university decides for itself.

- **Master's-level degree.** A 5-year BS-MS, MSc, MTech or MPharm opens almost every door. For you, Europe is often the fastest route: apply to adverts, start within months of an offer, and get paid from day one.

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- **4-year bachelor's.** It's the normal entry degree in the USA. Some UK universities accept it directly. In Germany and most of Europe, the realistic plan is a Master's first. Our free *Master's Admission in Europe 101* handbook covers that route.
- **3-year BSc.** Plan for a Master's first.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> "Can I do a PhD in Germany with a BTech?" is the question I hear most often. Usually the honest answer is "Master's first". Don't let anyone sell you a shortcut that doesn't exist.

You can run two routes at once. Many students answer European adverts all year and apply to US programmes once, in the autumn.

When a programme page doesn't make your eligibility clear, ask the office. Keep it short and specific, and read their FAQ first.

TEMPLATE Question to a graduate-school or programme office

```
Subject: Eligibility question - [Programme name] - [Your name]

Dear [Programme / Graduate School] Office,

I am interested in applying to [programme name] for the
[intake, e.g. next autumn] intake. I have read the admission
requirements and FAQ, but I could not find an answer to one
question.

I hold [degree, e.g. a 4-year BTech in Biotechnology] from
[University, India], with [CGPA, if relevant]. [Your question,
e.g. Is this degree sufficient for direct admission to the PhD,
or would I need a Master's first?]

Thank you for your help.

Kind regards,
[Full name]
[Email]
```

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06

Charles University, Prague, Czech Republic

CHAPTER 06 — WHERE TO LOOK

Finding positions and the right supervisor

There are two ways in: **answer an advert**, or **write to a professor** who has no advert. Do both.

Where adverts are posted

- EURAXESS (euraxess.ec.europa.eu/jobs/search), the EU's research-jobs portal. Filter by "First Stage Researcher (R1)", which means a researcher up to the PhD — that's you.
- University and institute job pages. Many positions at German universities, Max Planck, Helmholtz and Leibniz institutes appear only there.
- Nature Careers (nature.com/naturecareers), AcademicTransfer (academictransfer.com/en) (the Netherlands), jobs.ac.uk and FindAPhD (findaphd.com) (mainly the UK).
- Professors' own lab websites, under "Join us" or "Open positions".
- Our free live PhD position board (emergingscholarscouncil.com/phd-positions).

Structured programmes (IMPRS, graduate schools, MSCA networks, the EMBL International PhD Programme for life scientists) run calls with fixed deadlines, often once or twice a year. Note when each one in your field usually opens.

How to read an advert

Read the **funding and contract** first: is it paid, how much, for how long? If that's missing, ask before you apply. Then the **requirements**: separate "required" from "desirable". Then the **project**, the **documents** they want and the **deadline**. Some adverts close early once they find someone, so don't wait for the last day.

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> **TIP**
>
> Don’t wait for a 100% match. If you meet most of the “required” items, apply, and show clearly how you meet them.

Writing to professors without an advert

Many professors, especially in Germany, take students who write to them directly. This is called **cold emailing**. It works best when you choose groups by their recent research, not by university rankings, and when every email is clearly written for that one person. Keep a simple sheet of who you wrote to, when, and what happened.

Choosing a supervisor

Your supervisor shapes your PhD more than the university’s name. A famous professor with no funding or no time for you is worse than an early-career professor who is building a group and wants you to succeed.

- [ ] The group has published in your area recently.
- [ ] There’s a sign of funding: a grant, an advert, or a recent new student.
- [ ] Recent PhD graduates finished and went somewhere you’d like to go.
- [ ] The professor is still at that institute. Websites lag behind.

GREEN FLAG	RED FLAG
Clear answer on funding and its length	“We’ll find money later”
You may talk to current students alone	Students avoid your questions
Students publish and finish on time	Many left without finishing

On a first call, ask how the position is funded and for how long, how often the professor meets students, how long PhDs in the group usually take, and whether you can talk to a current student. Professors expect the money question. A good supervisor will be glad you asked.

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07

University of Manchester, UK

CHAPTER 07 — APPLICATION DOCUMENTS

Your application documents

Most applications are decided on paper before anyone meets you. Here's what each document has to achieve, and the mistakes I see most.

A word on AI

Draft with AI if you like, then rewrite it in your own words. Never send AI text as it is. Generic AI language sounds the same in every application, and it makes you sound the same too.

The CV

A research CV puts your **research first**. The reader should see within seconds what you've worked on, which techniques you can use, and what came out of it. Education, publications, awards and referees follow.

Common mistakes:

- Listing duties ("performed experiments") instead of the question you asked and what you found.
- Making it long. Short and focused reads better than everything you've ever done.
- Inflating your role or authorship. Professors know each other, and they check.
- Ignoring local custom. Conventions differ by country, for example on photos. Look at CVs from that country.

This is the part we work through one-to-one in mentorship — every CV tells a different story.

The email to a professor

Your email has one job: make a busy professor want to open your CV. That means:

- **Personalise it.** Mention their actual work, specifically. "Your work is very interesting" says nothing.

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- **Connect it to you.** Show how your own research experience fits their questions.
- **Keep it short.** Many professors read email on a phone.
- **Make it easy.** A clear subject line, your CV attached, files named with your name.
- **Follow up politely** if you hear nothing. Then move on.

The biggest mistake is the same paragraph sent to hundreds of people. Professors can tell in two lines.

This is the part we work through one-to-one in mentorship — every email is different.

The motivation letter

For advertised positions and structured programmes, you'll often need a **motivation letter** (also called a cover letter). It should answer three questions: why this research, why you, and why now. Use the advert's own requirements as your guide, and back every claim with something you actually did.

Common mistakes: retelling your CV line by line, long stories about childhood dreams, praise without substance, and one letter sent unchanged to every position.

The research proposal

You need a proposal mainly when you apply for your **own funding**, such as a DAAD scholarship. Talk to your host professor first and build the proposal from that conversation. A proposal written alone, for a lab you haven't spoken to, rarely fits.

A good proposal asks a specific question that can be answered in a PhD, shows you know the group's recent work, explains the methods, admits what could go wrong, and has a realistic timeline.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> DAAD sets the page limit and required parts for its proposals. Read the current call on DAAD India (daad.in/en) before you write.

This is the part we work through one-to-one in mentorship — every project is different.

References

You need referees who know your research: usually your thesis supervisor and one or two other professors you've worked with. Ask them weeks before any deadline, and before you list them anywhere. Send your CV and a short list of where you're applying. Keep them updated.

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TEMPLATE Asking your own professor for a reference

Subject: Request for a reference – PhD applications – **[Your name]**

Dear Prof. **[Surname]**,

I hope you are well. I am applying for funded PhD positions in **[field]** in **[countries]**, starting around **[month and year]**. Since I did my **[thesis / project]** on **[topic]** in your lab, you know my research work better than anyone.

Would you be willing to act as one of my referees? Some programmes will contact you by email, and some ask for a letter through an online form.

I have attached my CV, a short note on what I did in your lab, and a list of the positions I am applying to, with deadlines.

Thank you very much for your support.

Kind regards,
[Full name]
[Phone with country code]

English tests, transcripts and APS

Many programmes and visas ask for IELTS or TOEFL. Some accept a **medium-of-instruction letter** from your university (confirming your degree was taught in English). Check each programme.

Scan all mark sheets and certificates clearly and keep them in order, in one tidy PDF. For Germany, also check whether you need an **APS certificate**. APS India checks Indian degrees for German universities and visas.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> Who needs APS has differed for students, doctoral candidates and researchers on a contract. Check APS India (aps-india.de) and your German university before you apply for a visa.

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08

Imperial College London, UK

CHAPTER 08 — INTERVIEWS

Interviews and offers

An interview means you look right on paper. Now they want to see you explain your work, think on your feet and fit the group.

It may be a video call with the professor (treat it as an interview, even if it feels informal), a short talk on your main project followed by questions, a panel in a structured programme, or a chat with the group's PhD students. US programmes often invite shortlisted applicants for a recruitment visit, in person or online.

They often ask:

- Tell us about your main project. Why did you do it this way?
- What was the hardest problem, and how did you solve it?
- Explain one technique on your CV. What can go wrong with it?
- Why this group? What do you know about our recent work?

Preparation checklist

- [ ] I can explain my main project in 2 minutes and in 10 minutes.
- [ ] I've read the group's most recent papers and the advert again.
- [ ] I can explain every technique on my CV, including its limits.
- [ ] I've practised my talk out loud, timed, several times.
- [ ] I have three or four real questions for them.
- [ ] My camera, microphone and internet work, with a backup.

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> **TIP**
>
> If you don't know an answer, say so, then think aloud: "I haven't done that, but here's how I'd approach it." Professors want to see how you think. Send a short thank-you note the same day.

After an offer

Get the offer **in writing** before you accept. Check the monthly amount (and the share of E13 in Germany), the contract length against how long PhDs there usually take, the start date, teaching duties, and who helps with the visa. If you decline, say so quickly and politely, so the place can go to someone else.



Durham University, UK

CHAPTER 09 — SCHOLARSHIPS

09 Scholarships you can apply for yourself

Most funded PhDs in Europe don't need a separate scholarship: the money comes with the position. But some scholarships let you bring your own funding to a professor who has no open post. Scheme names last for years; amounts, deadlines and rules change. Always read the current call.

DAAD Research Grants – Doctoral Programmes in Germany

This is the main DAAD scholarship for a full PhD in Germany. Use the exact name in your applications.

- You find a German professor who agrees to host you, or get a confirmed place in a structured programme.
- You apply to DAAD with your proposal, the professor's invitation letter and your documents. Shortlisted candidates are usually interviewed.

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- DAAD pays a fixed monthly amount (approx., 2026: about €1,300 a month), generally not taxed, plus support for health insurance, travel and research, and in some cases family allowances.
- Funding is given one year at a time and can be extended, up to four years.

In science and engineering, good English is normally accepted if the host lab works in English.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> Eligibility has included limits on how long ago you finished your last degree and how long you've already lived in Germany. In recent years the call for Indian applicants closed in the autumn, for funding about a year later. Read this year's call on DAAD India (daad.in/en).

FROM MY OWN EXPERIENCE

I got my LMU PhD by answering a fully funded job advert. I also applied for a DAAD fellowship, because it looked better on my CV, and switched to DAAD funding when it came through. A job offer doesn't stop you from applying.

DAAD also has programmes for students already doing a PhD in India, such as bi-nationally supervised doctorates and short research stays. Search the DAAD database (daad.de/en/study-and-research-in-germany/scholarships) with "doctoral candidates".

Other schemes worth knowing

- **Fulbright-Nehru Doctoral Research Fellowships (USA).** Not funding for a full US PhD. It's for scholars **already registered for a PhD in India**, to spend several months researching in the US. Details on USIEF (usief.org.in/fellowships/fulbright-nehru-doctoral-research-fellowships).
- **Commonwealth Scholarships (UK).** When I checked in October 2026, India was not on the eligibility list for the Commonwealth PhD Scholarships. Lists change, so check the Commonwealth Scholarship Commission (cscuk.fcdo.gov.uk/scholarships).
- **Erasmus Mundus.** It no longer funds doctorates; today it funds joint Master's programmes. Joint PhDs now run mainly as MSCA Doctoral Networks. If someone offers you an "Erasmus Mundus PhD", check what it really is.
- **Government of India schemes.** Overseas scholarships for Master's and PhD study exist for students from certain communities, with income and age limits. See the National Overseas Scholarship portal (nosmsje.gov.in).
- **University and institute fellowships.** Read each programme's funding page and ask what you can be considered for.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> If a scholarship needs a host professor's letter, contact professors months before the deadline. They need time to agree a project and write the letter.

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10

University of Warwick, UK

CHAPTER 10 — MONEY AND VISAS

Visas, money and moving

A funded PhD lets you live decently, but rarely luxuriously. Plan your money from the first month.

Germany: tax and health insurance

- With a contract, your employer deducts income tax and social security (health, care, pension, unemployment and accident insurance). You're in the public health system through your job.
- Scholarship holders usually need their own health insurance. DAAD scholarship holders get insurance support from DAAD.
- Once you hold a Master's, the cheap student health insurance rate is usually not open to you. Ask the insurer before you choose.

Cost of living

Rent is the biggest cost almost everywhere. Don't trust one number from a blog. Read your target university's cost-of-living page, ask current PhD students what they pay, and start looking for housing as soon as you have an offer. In many cities it takes months.

Visas

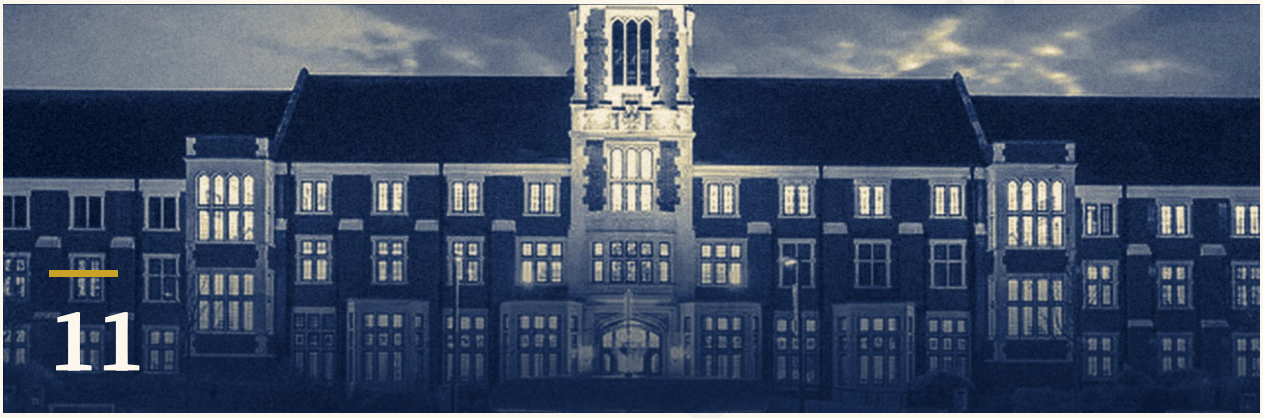
- **Germany.** Doctoral candidates can choose a study visa or a research visa, depending on their situation. A contract or scholarship usually counts as proof of income. Check Make it in Germany (make-it-in-germany.com/en) and book your appointment early.
- **UK.** You'll need a Student visa and must pay the Immigration Health Surcharge. PhD graduates can usually stay longer on the Graduate visa than Master's graduates. Check GOV.UK.

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- **USA.** You'll need an F-1 visa and an I-20 form from your university. Check the State Department's student visa page (travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/student-visa.html).

Many countries let family join PhD researchers, under conditions such as income and housing. Ask early; family visas take extra time.

> **CHECK THE CURRENT RULE**
>
> Visa rules change often, and no one can promise a visa outcome. Use only official government sites and your university's international office. Ignore anyone who promises results.



Loughborough University, UK

CHAPTER 11 — HONEST TALK

The honest part, and your 90-day plan

Here's what nobody puts on Instagram.

Silence is normal. Many professors never reply. They're busy, and many have no position right now.

> *"Silence is not a verdict on you."*

Rejections are normal too. Strong students get rejected for reasons that have nothing to do with them: an internal candidate, a funding delay, a changed project. Reply with a short thank-you. Sometimes the same professor writes back months later.

It takes longer than you think. From first email to first day in the lab, plan for many months. Start earlier than feels necessary.

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One round is information, not failure. If a round ends without an offer, change one thing — your list, your email, your CV — and run the next one.

Look after your mind. Loneliness, anxiety and feeling like an impostor are common in the first year abroad. It's not weakness. Use counselling services and your graduate office early, and find people outside the lab.

Watch out for scams. No real PhD position asks you to pay a fee to a professor or an agent. Check that every advert also appears on the university's own site. Nobody honest can promise a place, a scholarship or a visa.

> *"You don't need luck. You need a good list, honest documents, steady follow-up and the patience to run more than one round."*

Your 90-day plan

Ninety days is enough for one well-run round. Print this page and tick things off.

Days 1–15: get ready

- [ ] Pick your route and two or three countries.
- [ ] Write a research-first CV and scan your transcripts.
- [ ] Ask your referees.
- [ ] Check your English-test situation.
- [ ] Set up a tracking sheet.

Days 16–30: build your list

- [ ] Find research groups that truly fit you, using their recent papers.
- [ ] Save adverts from EURAXESS, job pages and the portals above.
- [ ] Note structured-programme calls and US deadlines.

Days 31–60: send and apply

- [ ] Send personalised emails in small batches, and follow up politely.
- [ ] Apply to every suitable advert with a tailored letter.
- [ ] Prepare a short talk on your main project.

Days 61–90: talk, adjust, repeat

- [ ] Take every call. Send a thank-you note the same day.
- [ ] Plan funding with any professor who wants to host you.
- [ ] Review what got replies, improve one thing, and start the next round.

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